

Red Sea/Seeing Sky

You lie flat, torn asunder— gifted with a laceration that spans the length of your chest, from the centre of your collar bones down your navel. Your ribs protrude at varying angles, seen in the corners of your eyes; milk white bone, cracked and pried. The nerves that are unintended to meet the air shiver in greeting. Hands — your hands — lie by your sides, helpless in your plight.

You are gasping, wordless and bare; choked, as blood foams from your mouth. The taste of it fills you with dread.

This is how you wake.

There is no pain, you note, somewhere among the nausea and inherent wrongness that plagues you thoroughly. You are cold and in agony, but not in pain— neither are you numb. Coughing up the blood from your mouth shakes you and you discover that, rather than pain, you feel everything else.

The jump of your lungs, the press of your diaphragm, the slow clawing of your stomach from eating nothing at all. Your bones ache— your spine contorted with the way you are lying, your skull pounding from fractures.

You are held together by ligaments and strands of muscle. Breathing is uncomfortable and difficult.

But you do breathe, regardless, because you are alive, still. Past the point of agony and rushing into mental misery; your body demands life. And it provides on instinct alone.

So you swallow your blood instead of hacking it up, finding the taste of iron to be the least of your current concerns. Your lungs work— not for long, you know, as the cool air dries up the pair of organs.

And you are embarrassed to admit it, but you take a moment to question as to what other vitals organs are within the body. Your brain is fine— you are thinking, so you will assume it's fine. Your eyes work well enough— though it's all rather blurry. You are able to make out the crimson red that makes up the sky and the sun that stares back at you.

It hits you, a moment later, whilst in the middle of scanning your body mentally. Somewhere between the thin plank of wood which you have been laid upon and the sound of water swaying around you.

As you realise: you don't have a heart.

The constant metronome; the origin of life. Currently, you lack it.

Things become a little clearer after that discovery—astounding; the leaps the mind will take to turn delusion into hope.

You lie helpless in a boat, floating across the water. Turning your head, you see past the rim of this seemingly small ship and find that you are staring at the Bloodwaters. A viscous sea, coloured as the mirror to the sky, made from the tears of the sun. Be it anger or sadness—the stories do not specify. But you personally imagine it to be joy that makes the water. A sadistic star, always in the process of a supernova.

You turn your head.

The Ferryman hums in the still, cold air. He stands tall, enough so that you can see him past your ribs. Gently, he pushes his oar in rippling water, swaying the boat—a jarring contrast to the self-satisfied smile he bares. His song is calming, unfitting and you'd tear his throat out if you were not in the condition you are currently in.

And he gaze is on you—has been, this whole time, shadowed by a out-of-place train conductor hat that makes him look much less imposing. A faint amusement crawls up his face a moment later as he starts to bend down closer.

You open your mouth and cough up more blood.

It is a violent motion that causes a positive feedback loop. A coughing fit—a fight to breathe, breathing to cough, blood interspersed at different intervals to keep it interesting. Your lungs pound with the fit and an ache settles into your diaphragm. You inhale your blood in failed attempts to gain some air, causing you to choke at moments. Your hands dig into the wood of the boat as you force strength into them. They do not raise as you wish they could. The sky blurs further—the sun stares down at you. Judgement in its gaze.

Realistically, this should end in, at worst, several minutes. However, realistically, you should not be alive without a heart.

Misery loves audience—something along those lines.

Water splashes across your face and certainly into your chest cavity. The shock of it—the sheer cold and split second inability to breathe at all—breaks the fit with a sharp gasp. You cough a few

times more, head turned away from the sudden chill, as blood leaves your lungs and air makes way.

Panting, like a tired dog; a tortured soul.

A moment longer of taking back stolen air and you realise the boat has stopped. So has his song. You blink. The Ferryman kneels – squats – down in front of you. His oar lies flat behind him.

“That was a rather nasty fit you had right there,” he says, smiling. His hat tips down, covering his eyes completely. “You’re welcome.”

You, lungs full of nothing and everything except air, only stare at him. He did stop your coughing fit– albeit harshly.

His smile turns wide and with much more mirth as, slowly, his hands slide underneath your neck and your knees. You are lifted from your spot, aching and miserable, still, but now carried like a princess– though at arms length away. A soundless noise of complaint leaves you as your organs shift in open air. Your head spins from the movement as he turns to the side.

And your stomach drops as he does to you.

Baby Bird/Juvenile Fish

Forget before– this is agony. Anguish at its finest, death’s granddaughter: torture.

Water fills you completely, seeping into your muscles and underneath your lungs. Your arms flail with sudden weightlessness, trying to gain a grasp on anything, everything, nothing at all. They settle on yourself as you press them over your chest in attempt to keep everything still. The feeling of it is odd at best– surreal at worst, but you’re not going to complain if it gets the job done.

You hold your breath – your lungs in your hands – and look. Bloodwaters is inherently thicker than average lakes, a call to its moniker. But it does not have the same opaqueness as normal blood. This, you are sure of, as your own blood slips through your fingers and becomes clouds of light red.

In other words, you can see.

It is a blinding crimson, infinite and forever. You imagine its infinity is comparable to that of numbers– it stops when you do. It is also incredibly difficult to see and you can't hold your breath forever. And if the stories tell true,

You are not the only thing in here.

A race, then; the first to survive gets to live.

Problem: you are near certain that you can't move your legs. It's only now – as you stop focusing on the feeling of your open chest – that you realise you are unable to feel your lower half, not properly. Broken bones grind against each other, displaced knees and cracked ankles. Your legs turn to weights in their uselessness.

And your hands are pressed over your chest, busy keeping yourself together. You are also underwater without gills. Death may as well be at your neck at this point.

In your pessimistic – pragmatic – contemplation, something of a deeper red meets the corner of your eye. You turn and– well, how incredibly convenient.

A heart pulses, a distance away, floating in the middle of nothing, just as you are. It is what you are lacking, you remember after a moment. Getting to it proves a little difficult, however. But you have to try regardless. Just as your lungs stole air to live; you'll steal from the seas for your own survival.

You try to move your legs – the broken and mangled ones, the only pair you have. They do not move, naturally, and much to your predicament.

So, as the only other method, you remove your arms from your chest and push down. It's counterintuitive and agonising, but it's temporary– you hope. Fortunately, your legs, as they remain limp, act as weight that has you descending quicker.

Red water burns your eyes, desperation acting as adrenaline. Due to your environment, your depth perception is skewed. You cannot tell how far down the organ is from your stretched hands, but given your current luck, you assume it's farther down than beneficial to you.

And given your current luck, it only natural to be caught off guard by a flash of something dark and quick that swims across the top of your vision.

It circles, waiting, guarding. Stopping until you are looking right at it, slowly sinking still.

A human face of a thousand eyes, elongated into something that of an eel. Its mouth opens to show rows and rows of canine teeth— a carnivore, a predator. And you, its prey. Its body is long, so much so that most of it is consumed by the colour of the sea. From what is available to your blurry eyes, the thing could wrap around you thrice and a half at least.

You are

running out of air.

So, as it approaches, blinking its many eyes and opening its maw, you reach out with clumsy hands to grab at its face, finally finding purchase. Out of what you assume to be shock, the thing freezes, and you take the opportunity to climb atop its back and down its spine. Though sluggish, you are quick and mildly steady.

It start writhing half way through your climb, swaying with violent panic. The movement has your intestines unraveling into open red water. But you ignore it all as your goal becomes clearer and seemingly within reach.

With one hand clawing at the slick back of the thing – like soapy skin – your other firmly grasps at the, feeling a steady pulse.

Not a thought later, you shove it in your open chest, right next to your lungs.

Your skin sews itself back together. Your ribs, once protruding, snap back together and cage over your vital organs again. The feeling in your legs return, your arms have a bit more strength to them. And, suddenly, all that's left of your anguish is a thin pink line that runs up your torso.

That does not mean you can breathe underwater though. You have been here long enough.

And the thing underneath your hand seems to think so as well, as a thousand eyes narrow at you with a hatred unfounded. A soundless hiss comes out in air bubbles. Time is up.

With your newly healed feet, you push off of it, swimming with a newfound vigor. It snaps at your heels, a second of delay.

A race, as it has always been— more literal this time.

Spoiler: you win. It stops following as you nearly break the sea's surface. You agree with it in that regard— the sun is something to hide from. But respiration does not occur underwater and your lungs – now situated within properly – are burning.

You make it soon enough, emerging from Bloodwaters with a gasp and few coughs. The sun stares down at you. You are no longer agony's victim. Just the regular sort.

Swimming to land with all your bodily functions proves easy enough. Climbing on is a little harder as you press your fingertips into the pavement. But your hands manage and you push yourself out of the water.

You flop onto hard cement, lying flat on your back as you did when you woke, and stare at the open sky.

You've won the race.

Adaption/Condemnation

You find clothes somewhere along the way— shoes a little later, once the walk has left indents and a raw static in your heels. Bloodwater slips down your neck, staining the collar of your shirt a light red. You don't mind, and neither does the shopkeep; faceless as they are.

Here, in the Port, people are not fully made.

They are flesh and bone, heart and lung, but lacking in character and person. They have instinct, though, as you poke one in the centre of their blank canvas face and have a hand wrap around your wrist in response. A mindless thing with a firm hold. A terrible hunter; a bag of meat. You rip your hand out from their grasp, causing them to fall over the counter with a solid thud.

They do not get up. With that, you leave the store through the broken display window.

The Port is loud with animal sounds. The many legs of insects, the wind of vultures. Not even the half-made make a sound— no throat to scream, no mouth to talk.

You walk, trying to find the way Inland.

See, the Port and Inland may as well be considered to a sea's away from each other with the amount of physical separation there is, all whilst being right next to one another. It's a wall that does it, for the most part, towering high and indomitable. Dark brick with no notches – its not something to be climbed.

That, and any life that touches it withers upon contact.

So you look for the gate, because there is one, despite the efforts of separation.

You find it, eventually. Guarded lazily by an artist— a sculptor. Their clay— flesh and bone— stacked into a tall pile beside them. The origin of the half-made; the third god; the Mother Mad.

The sun above watches, heavy in its gaze.

They — with fingers clumsy and thick — push meat into place, making a face shaped to be human. There is the cracking of bone as the spine is set straight, the sound of clicks as joints pop into place. A splash of water as something is disposed into Bloodwaters. And then what must be a cooing sound, as Mother Mad turns their creation in their hands.

Their mouth is wide with a smile, cheeks split with shifting stone. Eyes forever open, legs never moving, for they are stone, set in place. The wall was built around them, stories say, and the artist became the guardian. It is a contrast— from high walls to a guard that would not — could not — hunt if need be.

You step closer. The sound of shoes against stone has the god turning their head with a loud clink. Stone crumbles into pebbles under their chin. Their face is full of fractures, hands — the many there are — still, in the air.

“Pretty human,” their voice is low, calm and coy. “Come to help, have you?”

You step closer, having to look up as they tower over you. In their madness, they are aware of what you want. But you will not have it until they grant their own wishes. So you nod with a hesitation unnoticeable to the excitable god.

Heavy hands clap with pleasure; a rumbling quake comes from their form. “A pretty model, a reference lovely. Help me, human, how do I make one of you? Child of my sister, I wish to make her a child as pretty as you. Come, help, won’t you?”

It is a harmless request, you think, walking over and standing where they direct. They watch carefully, as if you are about to escape at any moment. They cannot chase you, after all— it is not a baseless precaution.

So you stand, as Mother Mad makes a soft cooing sound, scooping up lumps of flesh from their pile and slapping it down on the space next to you. The harsh sound startles you.

The god notices, though gaze still on the mound of newly placed muscle. “Sorry, sorry,” they comfort, a few hands making some pacifying gestures towards you while others work with the lump. “Excited. That’s all I am. I promise. Sorry.”

You don’t reply, simply watching the way they mold the material into something more human like. You will admit, they are very good at making bodies– the new figure looking recognisable to your own, though with some changes. Its shoulders are smaller, face more pointed– prettier, you realise, smaller and slim.

You don’t take much offence; you rather a similar figure than an identical one.

The water splashes with waves a distance away. Its rhythmic until it’s not, and the sea’s subtle melody turns to discord.

Up rising from sea, stepping onto the port, is the form of you. Translucent and vague, face obscured by being alone, but it is still identifiable. Perhaps only to you. It walks closer, suspensefully, with an intent to scare or disturb. It does a little, instinctually. But it’s a ways away so you swallow the fear and level your expression.

“Pretty human,” Mother Mad murmurs soft, dragging your attention back. And while the body is near perfect, its face is unsettling. Dents in flesh where orifices should be; mouth stretched to an uncanny proportion. A caricature, though inaccurate.

And they must notice, because Mother Mad stares. First at you, then at their creation. Once, twice, and almost a third time. “Horrid,” they mutter, looking into where the eyes would be on their sculpture. “Ugly and worthless.”

Their hands dig into the soft meat of the husk’s shoulders – waist and hips – displacing the flesh like a soft clay. The sound of slow grinding stone; air between a mortar and pestle. “Can I not make a doll pretty as hers? As special as hers? Why? Am I not of the same blood?”

With might, they haul the sculpture of flesh and bone up and to the side– splashing into the sea’s red water. It is so strong, in fact, that you think you see that the transparent double of yours step to the side out of shock, looking back at the water where it came from.

A loud clack and you turn your head. Mother Mad bends forwards – towards you – hands stretched out to grab. And in some turn of pure fortune, you are just out of reach.

“Come, help,” they whisper; bellow; speak with rippling calm. They’re having a tantrum.
“Come, human. Pretty, very pretty, human. I can make you better. Let me understand your making.”

You don’t move.

Expression twisted, the cracks close as their face aligns right. Lo and behold; a visage made for anger. “You promised to help.”

You did no such thing, and your face must show it because the god recoils at the judgment, as if struck. You would pity it, but your dues have been paid, so there’s really no need for you to be here anymore.

Mother Mad nearly snaps themselves in half trying to drag you back, staring wide in imaginary betrayal. But formed into stone as they are, you simply step by. The god; the third Mother, screams in rage, curses both you and the sun in the same breath.

Congratulations: you made it Inland.

Wayward Curiosity/Ignorance Uncured

Bus maps are the bane of your existence. Part of you must have known this instinctually, for you feel your shoulders sag at the sight of coloured blobs, spread out like dipping paper into water. You are dizzy five minutes in.

Question: how do you read a map with all colours and no general structure?

Answer: you don’t.

So you don’t, simply turning your back to it and waiting at the stop in silence. The weather is nice enough— damp air with the smell of a cold day. The sun radiates no warmth for you to bask in; you don’t mourn the hot days.

Inland differs from the Port in that the people are not half-made and faceless. There are people—the odd folk that stare through their windows, through open slivers of townhouses and apartment spires. They don’t really do much else. You compare them to bugs, a bother to think about, but nothing of real concern.

A few buses roll by, some of them not stopping at all. Your eyes catch on the windows of some, making very direct eye contact with the people pressed against the glass. You think you see some

of them scrambling to the bus doors as if trying to rush out to get you. But the bus keeps going and so do they.

And it's a little funny until you see that figure again. Translucent and vague; similar face to yours. Your Shadow sits in one of the buses that pass by. And just as you see it, it is gone.

You blink.

Not as funny.

A few buses later and boredom is apparent, multiplying in your bones and blood as a self-synthesized virus. Time's construct is eternity, and you are doing your best to stay awake. There are no seats and you are not sitting on the floor— so you may very well fall face first if you doze off.

Soon enough, your bus rolls in, empty and alone. The doors open to reveal a man with a train conductor hat.

“Commuter,” he greets, a soft curl to his voice. “Lovely to see you in one piece.”

A joke, you think, stepping on the bus.

“No fare today,” he tilts his head to the broken machine on his side, a soft static hum. “Lucky you, it seems. A free ride. ”

You give a firm nod and turn to take your seat further into the bus.

Curled into the back seat— furthest from the front — you rest your head against the window. And the bus moves.

There is an exhaustion, nestled in your waterlogged chest, that beats with your blood. It has your eyes slipping shut — despite the harsh rattle of the window your ear presses against — and dragging you down into a dreamless sleep. A light nap; a short sleep. And when you do wake, your eyes are still closed.

Because you learn that the people do not bother the resting, just as they do not bother the dead.

But it happens, sometimes, on instinct. That need to witness. Your eyes flicker open at the faint feeling of another sitting next to you, only for you to realise that it was a phantom. And the scene outside catches your eye— red clouds and red skies, as the sun stares right at you. It seems like

your are flying. Which strikes you as odd because you can feel the faint rumbling of the street underneath your seat– the rattling window against your head.

Yet the hum of the Ferryman stays persistent.

So, you close your eyes again.

A moment later, you open them from that phantom feeling next to you. This time, you find the sight of red trees with white trunks. A forest of them, with the low wet sound of road kill to score it. Blood slatters where your head lays, an animal wails in pain.

You rest again.

The bottom of the sea, the tunnel through towering mountains, up building spires– your sleep is dreamless, your reality is imaginary. The world shifts in your gaze, an album of moments right before you. And through it is the song of the Ferryman, humming his melody.

Head pressed against the window, you fall into soft slumber. A moment of death in the ever changing world. Respite; rest.

And when you open your eyes once more, the bus is empty and hollow. Dim lights fill your vision as you take in the scene. Abandoned; you are alone. And the outside looks just as it did before you got on the bus. The people peer at you through windows and doors, watching, waiting. You must make a terribly boring spectacle.

Slowly, with sleepy limbs, you stand and walk towards the front of the bus, where the Ferryman no longer sits. The rumble of the engine persists, still, as you realise there is no ignition to turn off the bus. It's to your benefit as with a firm pull, you open the doors and step out.

Where your Shadow stands, waiting.

There is that fear– instinctive and choking. You freeze rather than fight, standing on the last step of the bus and watching.

Unideal.

So, with will, you turn around, close the doors and sit in the drivers seat. One hand on the wheel, the other on the shift– you slam your foot into the gas pedal and drive away. You don't know how to drive a bus, but you'll figure it out.

Responsibility/Responsive

You don't figure it out. It is, in fact, a miracle that you don't crash and die. You do crash, however, running straight into a wall when trying to swerve around traffic. While you don't make it far, you have made it away. Away enough where your Shadow is an afterthought in the wake of everything else.

'Everything else' being extreme traffic.

You imagine that even if the bus map from before was legible, it would still be incredibly complicated. Streets bend and curve around bases of apartment complexes. Lights flicker in both colours primary and secondary. And there is an incessant cacophony of honking as the roads pile with cars.

The front of the bus smokes as you leave it– and you hear a faint clicking.

You run; it explodes.

Yet, despite that, the traffic remains undisturbed, undeterred.

You walk around cars, peering into tinted windows, and find faceless faces, mindless drivers. Some packed as clown cars, some with only the driver. And some who stare right at you. You try to open a few of them, not wanting to walk the whole way, and find that none of them have door handles to open with. Very few have doors, in fact. As if made for eternal reason of staying in place.

A car honks; another in response, and it's a feedback loop that travels down and around. You are transfixed, horrified. You also cannot stay, for your Shadow chases.

So you attempt to walk around cars, wincing at their loud blares. Slivers of concrete are difficult to reach as the space between bumpers and tailgates are about the same as your knees. You jump over the cars whose front kisses the back of another– hand on the hood, you push yourself over.

You are lost in this maze of machinery, and asking around proves useless.

The sun stares down at you. You feel the weight of something closer.

And somewhere – somewhere you can't see – your Shadow lurks closer. If Mother Mad is a poor hunter, than your afterimage is a taunting one.

You run. So does it.

The Hunt begins in full. You jump between cars, it slithers under. Snake against man – how long has that battle been fought? And witness to it all is the sun that will not tell this story. Perhaps it will laugh, though, at your plight, and rise the Bloodwaters until it drowns out the Port. Put the stone stature god out of their misery for once.

Something grabs at your ankle– you kick it off without looking. The impact is soft, but solid– as if yet to be fully formed. And the hold loosens, letting you jump over the hood of another vehicle. Just as you do, the same car honks loud and long– the sound of it startling you to nearly fall. Long and attention grabbing; a contrast to the short and curt beeps of every other car.

You make it over, and upon doing so, you spot the passenger door open wide in greeting. You take the chance as it presents itself. Entering quick, you slam the door– followed by your Shadow slapping a translucent hand against the window.

And the driver laughs– a sound that stays in the throat like a hum. Tipping his train conductor hat, the Ferryman smiles at you. “So soon, Commuter?”

Your Shadow bangs against the window. You see cracks start to form.

The Ferryman’s smile wavers at its corners. “You crashed the bus, didn’t you?”

You think he’s asking just to ask, so you don’t answer. Instead, you give him a long and deadpan stare, urging him to move on forward.

He hums, leaning his chin against the top of the wheel. “I’m afraid I’ll need a fare this time. I’m sure you can afford, no?”

You stare at him a moment longer.

Filled with impatience for generally everything, you start climbing to the front of the car, pushing through the two front seats.

“Commuter–”

You reach over the Ferryman– one hand on the buckle, the other extended to the door handle. With the push of one, the seat belt comes undone; and the pull of the other, the door opens.

“*Commuter*–”

With a pair of pats to the conductor hat, you shove the Ferryman out the door– whom also crashes into your Shadow. Cushioning, you justify, as you close the door on the two of them.

Buckling your – his – seatbelt over your shoulder and waterlogged chest, you drag the shift to reverse and crash into car behind you. A loud honk comes from it, but you pay little mind. Just as you pay little mind to the sight of your Shadow dragging the Ferryman out of the way in the corner of your eye, as you put the car back into drive and turn the wheel.

So be it: the roads are full and blocked. But the sidewalk isn't.

You drive on the empty pavement – small as it may be – nearly running over the Ferryman and your Shadow and scrapping off the side-view mirrors.

And you drive on. You don't know where you're going– getting behind the wheel does not fix that, much to your dismay – but you go regardless. Past the traffic, away from your Shadow, and hidden from the gaze from the sun.

Momentarily, you are free.

Fool's Parade/Heart Homicide

The car runs out of gas eventually, and you are left to walk the rest of your way. The streets are emptier further Inland you are– less towering buildings, less staring people. What they are replaced by are rolling fields in windless air. Long red grass under vibrant crimson skies. You stare for what must be an unnecessary length of time.

But you do stop. And you walk forward.

It's as you expect: an empty road sided by lengths of fields. And you don't mind, grateful to get away from the hectic noise of the roads.

And you keep walking.

And walking.

And walking.

And you have walked yourself a circle.

You know it– though nothing signifies it definitely. Your car– the one you borrowed – stole – from the Ferryman is not there. But the scene is the same, you know. Endless infinite fields remind you of Bloodwaters, drowning with an open chest. There are no stories about red and empty fields, but the feel is uncanny; infinite in the way numbers are. It does not help that you always feel that you are being watched – you are and you know it. But it becomes difficult to differentiate the sun from something else.

So you walk through the fields, abandoning the road in attempt to break the pattern.

And again you walk.

Walk.

Walk.

And you are sure of it– you have walked yourself a circle, staring at the road that you came from. A heavy sigh escapes you as defeat nearly takes you down.

“Is this the end, then?”

You look to where the voice comes from– up.

Rather than red skies, you are greeted with the mirror image of yourself. The roads and fields reflected next to your own reflection. Cracked roads and dead – dying – fields, your image stands in the centre of it all, neck bared as it tilts its head to look at you, just as you do.

“Will you rest, here; alone; quitting? So soon?”

You are different in the mirror. Weeping and hollow-eyed; you are nothing as you feel.

You don’t have an answer. So, in response, you continue walking.

And walking.

And walking.

Until you are back where you began.

“You will go insane like that,” your reflection over your head says. It is unkind, just as it is wise. “Or perhaps you have already gone insane.”

But what defines the insane?

“Will you walk again, oh reflection of mine? Or will you stay still and let me look at you proper?”

You walk, again.

And again.

And again.

A sigh comes from above. “Mother have mercy,” your other image sighs, face pinched in a frustration you don’t feel. “You really are just going to walk– what. What is with that face. Why are you smiling.”

Mouth stretch wide, you grin from ear to ear. It is very like you, you feel, to be frustrated with even yourself. And a laugh bubbles out of you.

The reflection ripples.

Perhaps you will walk forever, perhaps you won’t– that, you don’t know. But you do know that your feet are terribly sore and your laugh is watery because there is Bloodwater in your chest. You have driven two vehicles you have no licence to– stolen from the same man, no less. And you are lost in the middle of nowhere because you had nothing to pay for your fare.

Frankly, it is miserable and pathetic to recount. Currently, it is terribly funny.

You look up, smiling from exhausted laughter, and find that your reflection has stretched to unproportional lengths. No longer does it look like you, not really. Uncanny valley– that must be it. Long arms– longer than that of your body – and a wide mouth that opens to swallow you whole. Your hands – its hands – reach out to you – up/down – with needle fingers.

Its eyes zone in on you, predator to prey. A child promised a toy– you know that face better than you know your own.

So, as it reaches through the mirror, you do the same. Needle fingers meet flesh ones. And as it digs under your skin– you pull yourself up/your reflection down.

It lets out a surprised sound as its feet lose hold of the road on its side and you climb up by its arms. Crossing the mirror border, you grab it by the head and push yourself into its place, and it into yours. Replaced and reflected, you now stand on cracked roads.

Here, on the other side, you recognize the fields properly. The Joyous Garden. Made just to wither, birthing home to the sun's abandoned.

Looking up, you find a monster with long limbs and short legs. Its face— horrid and ugly — stares wide at you from below/above. A distorted scowl, it starts: “You—”

And a car runs it over.

Blood splatters across the road and the car— bits of it splatter into the fields, blending/bleeding into the health reds of it. There is an agony written across its face — still yours, though contorted — that you do not pity. Its fingers twitch. Once, twice

and are then stomped on by a vague and translucent foot.

The door closes with a clear sound. You watch from where you are as your Shadow bends down, lifting the arm of the roadkill. And when it falls limp, it stands, looking up/down at you.

It looks away, then around, and comes to a conclusion as you watch it start climbing up the car it drove here in.

You don't watch for long though, as you start running just as it has its foot on the hood.

Wise I am/Wisdom You Are

Running turns to walking as your feet grow sore, blisters worn into your skin. You don't stop, though, not to rest nor to wait. Your Shadow lingers close, you can feel, and you are not ready to figure out what happens when it catches up.

In your strive of survival, you keep going. Your knees and calves burn, but its better than not feeling them at all. Your heart and lungs work to keep you alive, moving, not quitting. It is a struggle that makes you human, you figure. In suffering, your blood flows faster. A dangerous mindset that you have been given.

Despite all that — all of this — what bothers you most is the silence. Hearing your own breathing above everything else, your own heart in your ears. It is quiet, and the wind does not sing as it

usually does. Part of you suspect that there is no air at all. You lived without a heart – temporarily, at least – you think you can live without your lungs.

It's a different agony. It settles in your bones, aching with isolation. Like the world has disappeared, and all that is left is you. Poor you, who ventures Inland.

Question: what is it that you do when you are lost?

Answer: you walk.

And you walk far. Your shoes – the ones from the Port– have worn into paper-thin soles, you may as well be walking barefoot. But something is better than nothing, you suppose.

The road turns to nothing as your path becomes water. Clear, blue water that reaches your ankles, healing it with its cool temperature. But you keep walking, still. The sound of it reminiscent to your waking; the only sound to fill the air. Silent no more, you feel more at peace.

Later in your walk, fields of dying grass turn to water lilies, floating on shallow blue. The glow in the dim sunlight, catching your eye for a moment before you turn away. Your path turns to a walkway; the Garden into the surface of a water bed. Your bones urge you to lay down, you knees buckle under the weight of yourself– but you keep going.

Then it's the sky that changes. From crimson to midnight azure – a thousand small suns – stars – stare at you in waiting. And you, back at them.

Eyes, many of them, stare at you, and you alone.

Here, you meet the second god – Mother Sorrow – in his home; Second Sky. God of nothing, left in empty lands and hollow hearts, the god is useless as they come. And you, stand under his gaze of a thousand, waiting for his command, no longer walking.

You fall to your knees, the pain of them pulsing through your legs. The cool water surrounds you in a cold embrace.

“Pitiful human,” he says, soft and cradling. The stars blink down, crying in stardust. “Rest, just this once.”

His hands are the sky, made of supernovas of dark blue stars, both burning and cold. Mother Sorrow bends down, just to hold you as carefully as he can. In the wake of his fingers, smudges of frost and burns are left on your cheeks. Your flesh peels with each stroke.

“Pitiful, sorry, human,” and he sobs – weeps – for you. “Let me help you. Sleep, here, in beds of overflowing clouds. A sky not as violent as hers. Child of my sister, distant blood of mine– stop your suffering. I can help.”

Your head is tilted up towards the sky. Neck open for taking– your hands grip his. This game is not a fun one; you have no plans to play.

“I can help you,” stardust tears; a thousand eyes. God of nothing, witness to everything. You tug at his hands to no avail, and he continues on. “Let me help you, pitiful human.”

The sound of water splashing comes from behind. But with your head held in the hands of a god, you cannot turn around.

You should’ve kept walking.

God of nothing; servant of the sun– Mother Sorrow lies as easy as he does cry. And he watches, overseer, over seeing– your hands dig into the wrists of the second god. He holds you tighter; the stars a little brighter.

“Pitiful human–”

You rip the sky open with bare hands– galaxies sliding down your wrist. Mother Sorrow wails, retracting at the pain. You, now set free, roll out of the way as your Shadow dashes to where you were once kneeling.

“Please,” Mother Sorrow cries. “Please, human of my sister; pitiful in your making, rest for once.”

You are running, with burning legs and water everywhere. Your Shadow on your heels.

You don’t know where you are going – still, time and time again. In what must be hysteria, you wonder which of the three gods would hear you if you prayed. And which one would listen to your prayers.

Water is surprisingly difficult to run through, you think, slipping before catching your footing. The lilies gather in clusters– in your stride, you crush them, and the god weeps for them rather than you, who is being hunted.

It is then that you look behind you – a mistake – and a hand grabs at your ankle, pulling you down. The back of your skull meets the water first, hitting the ground with loud impact. You are dizzy for a moment– likely confused– and wonder if you cracked your skull.

It doesn't matter in the end, though, as your Shadow stands atop you. Foot to your throat– your translucent and vague image stares down with no triumph or victory. Water to your ears– you still hear the second god sob. What for, you wonder, because you are resting, here, finally, just as he wished – wishes.

You're drowning again. Blue as the water may be, you still down in Bloodwaters, looking for a heart to stuff into your incomplete chest. This time, though, you suppose you can feel your legs. Perhaps too much so.

The foot presses down harder. You make a sound that comes from the throat.

Cold water; under starlight– you, child of the sun, your journey ends in the embrace of the Second Sky. Drowning half in the water, choking on the weight of yourself.

If you prayed to a god– who would answer? Mother Mad, stuck in stone; Mother Sorrow, constant with crying?

Or would it be Mother Joyous, watching as witness.

The sky – with blurry eyes, tear filled and watery – turns into that familiar crimson that has accompanied you throughout. Since beginning to now.

The sun stares down at you.

You close your eyes.

Worn Shoes/Broken Knees

You lie flat, chest unopened and bones set in place. There is a faint rumbling beneath you– your back, cushioned by seating. Comfort seeps into your bones, and warmth under your skin. You are intact, whole, and breathing in softly. Hands placed over your stomach, intertwined with yourself, the slow rise and fall of your stomach become worthy of note to your tired mind.

This is how you wake.

It takes a bit of effort, but you sit up and are greeted by the blaring lights through the train window. The image of the world moves quickly past your eyes. And you stare, fascinated by the light show. As if a child again, with a short attention span and a head full of questions– you feel young; younger than you are. Swirls of skies– you ride on clouds.

However, unlike before, you know where you are going. The train follows its rails, after all. There's very little mystery when it comes to its destination.

Stretching your legs, you note that the pain in them has lessened a considerable amount– still stiff, but not enough to hold you down. A hand over your heart, through water you can feel the pulse of your being. You are alive, still, despite everything.

You look around, turning your head to the sides and to your back. There is no one. Alone, you sit in the train car meant for many. But isolated as you are, the air is not quiet. The steady roll of the train in your fingers, the sound of it fill the air– you are surrounded with enough to not feel lonely. Your hands rest on the table in front of you, fingers crossed over one another, the calluses rubbing against soft skin.

And then comes the soft humming. A door slides open, revealing a man in a train conductor hat. He waves at you with a smile, walking over and sitting across. His hands rest in mirror to yours, fingers laced together and placed in front of him.

“So? How was it?” He asks, knowing.

You stare outside. The scenery spins as the train goes through a loop– you do not feel it from where you are sitting, so the contrast confuses you for a moment. But very few things make sense in the world, you figure.

“Mother Joyous has been waiting for you,” he says to no one – to you. There is a distinct discomfort around the name. And he continues, “you’re her favourite. She will be very happy to see you.”

You see the Port, Bloodwaters, the traffic jam, the spires of buildings. You see the Garden, the Second Sky– you see your journey, from beginning to end. Laid out across the world; you, the eternal vagabond, have seen far too much.

“Are you ready?”

You look at him. The Ferryman grins at your attention; like dog to bone.

You do not reply– you have no reply to give.

It is not a comfortable silence that fills the hole of your one-sided conversation – it is not silence at all, not really. It is a soft hum that comes from the back of his throat, a song from the heart for the hearing. The sound of accepting, if not a little suspenseful.

Your Shadow rests at your heels, attached as it should be. No longer can you run from it. It follows you as you tap your feet, leans back in your seat with you– when you do.

This is you, in your entirety. You, pretty and pitiful.

Child of the sun– you are going back home. Except you don't recall having a home. Yet you are going back to it.

The train stops.

“Come,” the Ferryman stands, hand open and stretch out to you. Carefully, you take it, raising yourself from the seat which you awoke from. This time, he does not drop you into a sea of viscous water. Instead, he leads you out the train, hand in his, and to a door of grand size. Towering higher than and building you have seen, golden and hidden in red skies– you stand before them.

“Are you ready?” He asks again, for no real reason.

You've thought about it; quietly, in the small corners of your mind, if you would ever be ready. For anything.

You shake your head.

He laughs. “Unfortunate, then.”

And with a step forward, the doors open.

Embrace/Abandonment

Mother Joyous is the sun of this land, eye watching closer than the thousand of Mother Sorrow's; hands more gifted than that of Mother Mad. The god of everything, origin of life as well as the end of it. She is radiant just as she is blinding.

She calls for her children, constantly, all the time. A loving mother she is. And you: most beloved, can only reply to her call with your presence.

You enter, shone in gold, haloed with the stuff. Her head stays above the clouds, past the ceiling of the room, but she sees you regardless.

“Child of mine,” does she smile? You do not know. “You have come to me. Good, good, you have done well. Just as you always have.”

Needle-thin fingers lower from the sky, coming to lift you from where you stand. The Ferryman, you see, steps back— smile wavering.

You are raised higher— your hands wrapped around her fingers in case her hold slackens. To this, she clicks her tongue. “Trust me, persistent child of mine. I would not drop something as precious as you.”

It is difficult to hear her with the rushing wind from your ascension— the hammering of your heart. You are scared— you would like to be put down.

Yet you are cradled in her palm, admired from afar— you are the child of the sun. And the sun stares down at you.

“You have journeyed well.”

A finger presses into the middle of your collar bones, and sinks under the skin. It seems like you’re forgoing many formalities today.

“Think this not as punishment, but as praise,” and she drags, all the way down, down, down, stopping at your navel. She speaks, voice of music, words of honey. To you, and you alone. “Think of it as purpose.”

And you are in

agony

once more.

Mother Joyous digs, beneath your ribcage, under your lungs— water pours out from your chest. You writhe, squirm, but do not beg. Clutching to her fingers, you are torn asunder. There is no

scream that leaves your throat, no breath for you to breathe. You are misery to an audience of one, tortured and suffering.

In the silence of your non-screaming, there is snapping bones. There is the violence of lungs to open air, of empty stomachs and overworked nerves, bare and raw. She hums, sugar sweet sound, sucrose syrup in her throat. It aggravates you further.

You cry, in the hand of your mother. Silent tears fall down your face as you are ripped for her desire and your detriment.

Soon, she stops. And every so carefully, she picks out your heart and holds it between the tips of needles. She raises her hand, blood dripping down her thin wrists, as she admires your metronome of an organ. Such a small thing in her hands; so vital to the living. And you – blurry-eyed – watches as the sun opens her mouth and swallows it whole. The organ disappears from the world, digested by the first god of this wretched world.

“Precious child,” she coos, content. Bringing you closer, burning your skin. “Lovely, persistent child.”

She looks at you for a moment longer. Then, gently, you are laid to the ground, open and bare; breathless and gasping.

The sun stares

down at you.

“My child,” Mother Joyous shines, her eye curved with love. “My favourite little thing. Come back to me, won’t you?”

And you, wracked with pain unimaginable, close your eyes.

Red See/Seaing Sky

You lie flat, torn asunder– gifted with a laceration that spans the length of your chest, from the centre of your collar bones down your navel.

This is how you wake.

End